shift in Europe's balance of power. After almost a century of war and peace, the 1907 Hague Convention further delineated the concept of neutrality famously applied in the case of Switzerland.[5] Clinton stated: 'If we [US] could get to that point with the regional powers in South Asia, that (they) would not recommence with the great game in Afghanistan, that would be a very worthy outcome'.[6] Nothing came out of it. Far from being stable or neutral (as the Afghan Taliban, even though fragmented, staged a comeback), Afghanistan today faces multiple security, political, and financial crises. Topping this is the fact that India and Pakistan continue to remain at odds with each other while the latter's alleged interference in Afghan domestic affairs has not ceased.

Although there are explanations for Pakistan's behavior towards Afghanistan, India's Afghanistan policy has elicited analogies of 'great game' and 'proxy warfare', or simply, strategic desire for access to material resources in that region, as causal explanations.[7] If anything, India's role in Afghanistan's international history (particularly from the mid-1960s onwards) has been overlooked. More generally, the voice of great powers tends to dominate the study of Afghanistan's wars, to the exclusion of a more regional perspective. This matters first, because it obscures the role of regional powers that may have had a far more enduring, and at times, critical influence on the situation. And it matters secondly because whilst commentators regularly call for a 'regional' solution to conflict in Afghanistan, there are fewer historical works that can contribute to understanding the role that regional actors have played in Afghanistan in the first place. A detailed interrogation of Indian policy debates and approaches towards Afghanistan will contribute towards filling this gap.

Despite having a vision of a strong, stable, sovereign, and territorially united Afghanistan, India's policy course has witnessed changes big and small over the past three and a half decades. In fact, similar to Clinton, former diplomat and current Indian vice president Mohammad Hamid Ansari stated in 2003 that a 'neutral status' is the best option for Afghanistan's persistent problems.[8] However, in contrast to this alleged aim of neutrality, between 1996 and 2001, India was staunchly against the Taliban regime and provided political, financial, and military support to the anti-Taliban United Front (UF), popularly known as the Northern Alliance. Marking a policy change with the entry of the coalition